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Volume XXXIII Number 15: For the week April 8-14, 2008, released on April 7

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Fax: 23316180; Cable: Livmedia, New Delhi

• Subscriptions: For assistance contact Customer Care India Today Group, A-61, Sector-57, Noida (UP)-201301;

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Faridabad; (0120) 2479900 from Rest of India (Monday-Friday, 10 a.m.-6 p.m.); Fax: (0120) 4078080;

e-mail: webcare@indiatoday.com; Mumbai: 022-24444423-6; Fax: 24444358 • Sales: Direct all trade enquiries to

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New Delhi • Regd. Office: K-9 Connaught Circus, New Delhi 110001 • Impact Offices: Trade Centre, 2nd Floor,

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India Ltd., 18-35 Milestone, Delhi Mathura Road, Faridabad-121007, (Haryana), at Thomson Press India Ltd.,

A-9, Industrial Complex, Maraimalai Nagar, District Kancheepuram-603209, (Tamil Nadu), and at Thomson Press

India Ltd., Plot No. 5-SA, TTC Industrial Area, Thane, Belapur Road, Airoli, Navi Mumbai-400708, (Maharashtra).

Published at K-9, Connaught Circus, New Delhi-110001.

• India Today does not take responsibility for returning unsolicited publication material.

I remember INDIA TODAY's first cover story on Bollywood in 1978. It was on Raj Kapoor's *Satyam Shivam Sundaram* and featured the reigning sex symbol Zeenat Aman. The film cost Rs 85 lakh to make, less than what producers spend these days on one song alone. Inflation, the hot topic of the day, affects every industry but even taking rising costs into account, Bollywood has never been bigger and more focused. More than Rs 3,000 crore in public and private money is being spent over the next 15 months on a variety of films.

The industry, once a fragmented conglomerate of individual producers, exhibitors from territories as disparate as north Bihar and Mumbai, and a handful of stars, has now consolidated into five major studios which are in the process of controlling the last mile of movie revenue. Star fees have gone up, as have the fees of talent down the line. Till last year, a big release was one that hit 1,500 screens. Now, they are talking in terms of a 2,000-screen releases. Revenue avenues that Bollywood had previously never explored—a theatrical release in Germany or mobile downloads—are now expanding rapidly. Records are being broken every year. Last year, 3.95 billion tickets were sold while revenues were Rs 5,600 crore.

That's a sea change from 2000 when Bollywood was accorded the status of an industry. At the time, it seemed a premature honour. The film factory was disorganised, run as fiefdoms by a few families, at the mercy of the star system and an undying 'formula' that alternated between vigilant justice and weepy family sagas. That period, when the industry went through a major financial slump, seems to have taught some hard lessons and Bollywood has emerged bigger and better in every respect. Filmmakers who had quit the system in disgust are now super busy, whether it is Saeed Akhtar Mirza or Jahnvi Barua. Youngsters from advertising, from FTII, or foreign film schools are now getting their big chance much faster and foreign majors are investing money in Indian films.

The flipside is that we also have bigger stars who are much more careful of their images, and so do fewer movies at higher fees. With Bollywood now so much a part of the national landscape, one flop can set an actor's brand value back by a year. But the change is palpable, whether it is in the larger budgets (10 films currently being shot have budgets of over Rs 50 crore) or in the increasing openness to ideas, from filmmakers and the audience. At INDIA TODAY, we have tracked Bollywood's ups and downs with considerable consistency, as befits its status, along with cricket, as a national obsession. This is our 33rd cover on Bollywood and its stars and one in which the stars, no pun intended, have never been more favourable. As our resident Bollywood expert Executive Editor Kaveree Bamzai says, "It's boom time for Indian cinema but oddly enough, lifestyles haven't become flashier. Life is certainly not imitating art but I'm sure it will soon."

Aroon Purie

(Aroon Purie)